

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

State sues over cuts to health care grants

Trump administration moves to slash \$100M in funding to Illinois

By Lisa Schencker and Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

President Donald Trump's administration is moving to cut more than \$100 million in federal health care grants for Illinois, a step that was quickly met with a lawsuit filed by Attorney General Kwame Raoul and his peers in three other states.

Illinois, California, Colorado and Minnesota sued the Trump administration Wednesday over the Office of Management and Budget's directive to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention to cut more than \$600 million in grants to those states. The grants, which could be terminated as soon as Thursday, are for states to track disease outbreaks, maintain and improve their data systems and collect public health data, according to the lawsuit.

"Rather than making life easier and more affordable for our families, Donald Trump is stripping critical public health funding with the singular goal of harming states he does not like," Gov. JB Pritzker said in a news release. "It's a slap in the face to the people of Illinois and the public health leaders who have stepped up as his (U.S. Department of Health and Human Services) takes a sledgehammer to public health infrastructure. Illinois will not stand by idly as Trump illegally cancels the Congressionally-allocated funding we are owed."

The U.S. Department of Health and Human Services did not immediately respond to a request for comment Wednesday evening, but a spokesperson said earlier this

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Laser dispute shuts airspace over El Paso

Bid to test weapon by Pentagon causes friction with FAA

By Seung Min Kim, Ben Finley, Morgan Lee, Mary Clare Jalonick and Josh Funk
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The sudden and surprising airspace closure over El Paso, Texas, on Wednesday — first announced as extending for 10 days but lasting only a few hours — stemmed from the Pentagon's plans to test a laser to shoot down drones used by Mexican drug cartels, according to three people familiar with the situation who spoke on condition of anonymity to share sensitive details.

That caused friction with the Federal Aviation Administration, which wanted to ensure commercial air safety and the two agencies sought to coordinate, according to two of the people.

Despite a meeting scheduled for later this month to discuss the issue, the Pentagon wanted to go ahead and test the laser, prompting the FAA to shutter the airspace over the city on the U.S.-Mexico border. The laser was used at some point, one of the people said.

Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said earlier that the airspace closed as the Defense Department and the FAA halted an incursion by Mexican cartel drones and "the threat has been neutralized." Drone incursions are not uncommon along the U.S.-Mexico border.

The restrictions were only in place for a couple of hours in the city of nearly 700,000 people, but it is unusual for an entire airport

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Valeria Reyes waves the Mexican flag while spinning around on the shoulders of Eleazar Herrera during a school walkout protesting the actions of ICE agents on Wednesday in Broadview. STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Students protest ICE in flurry of school walkouts

Some cite personal connections to immigration detentions and desire to make their voices heard

By Molly Morrow and Hope Moses
Aurora Beacon-News

Annette Mejia thought only a few students from each of Proviso Township District 209's three high schools would attend the walkout she and a few other students began planning last weekend.

Then, on Wednesday morning, several hundred showed up, leaving their classrooms in a student-organized protest of the Trump administration's continued mass deportation campaign.

"People kept repeating, like, 'Oh, we should do this. This is something worth fighting for,'" the Proviso East High School senior recalled.

Students walked to the sounds of Latin music and honking from passing cars as they made their way down Roosevelt Road to 25th Avenue, just a few blocks away from the Immigration and Customs Enforcement processing center in Broadview, where numerous protests have been held in the months since the Trump administration began its immigration crackdown in

Chicago, dubbed Operation Midway Blitz.

The crackdown in Chicago led to the detention of thousands and prompted resistance and solidarity by residents from all walks of life — from documenting detentions and the actions of federal agents to delivering candy on Halloween to those who didn't feel safe enough to go door to door amid the immigration crackdown.

But lately, students have taken action, organizing walkouts from their classrooms in protest of ICE. Some are going up against

the advice of school officials, the police and others in the name of making their communities more aware of what's been happening, citing personal connections to the recent immigration detentions and a desire to make their voices heard.

"This is what our world has come to: that teenagers had to walk out of their school to protest something that shouldn't even be existing," Mejia said Wednesday.

This is not the first time local students have organized in oppo-

Turn to Walkouts, Page 2

'Culture of violence' among agents, Martínez lawyers say



Marimar Martinez departs a press conference with attorney Chris Parente on Wednesday in Chicago after the release of body camera videos and text messages from the Border Patrol officer who shot her last year in the Brighton Park neighborhood. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Attorneys say they will file tort claim against Justice Department

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Lawyers for Marimar Martínez, the Chicago woman shot by a Border Patrol agent in October, said Wednesday newly released evidence in the case demonstrates how Trump administration officials "have created a culture of violence among their agents" where the shootings of U.S. citizens are "embraced, celebrated and promoted."

Investigative materials made public Tuesday showed that after shooting Martínez five times on Oct. 4, Border Patrol Agent Charles Exum joked about it in a text chat with colleagues, was called a "legend" by one of his fellow agents, and even received praise directly from his boss,

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INSIDE

Bondi, Dems clash at House hearing

Testimony heats up over Epstein records and moves made by the Department of Justice. **Nation & World**

'Ripped away from us by a gunshot'

Cook County judge gives man life sentence in 2020 Chinatown double homicide. **Chicagoland, Page 3**



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Cubs aren't shying away from goals

The Cubs open spring training with high expectations — and an embrace of that challenge. **Chicago Sports**

